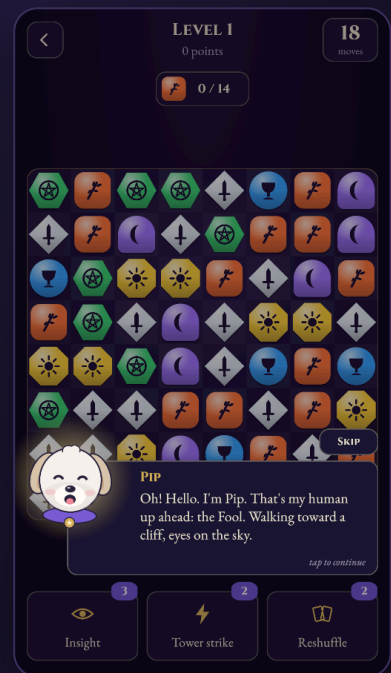
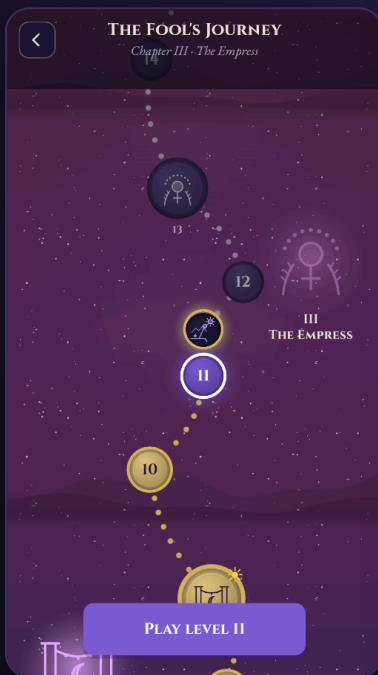




GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT · V2.0

ARCANA MATCH

Match the suits, walk the Fool's journey, and collect all 78 cards.



GENRE

Match-3 puzzle with a card-collection meta

PLATFORM

iOS and Android (portrait), mobile web build

ENGINE

Unity 6 · C#

AUTHOR

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DATE

September 2026

ARCANA MATCH

A tarot-themed match-3 for portrait phones, from concept to a playable build.

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1 • OVERVIEW AND PITCH

A calm, card-collecting match-3 along the Fool's Journey. Every level you win adds a tarot card to your deck; every chapter ends at a gate where you earn one of the 22 major arcana, in order, with Pip the dog telling the story.

THE GAME AT A GLANCE

GENRE	Casual match-3 puzzle with a tarot card-collection meta layer
PLATFORMS	iOS and Android phones, portrait; a mobile web build for playtests
SESSION	1 to 3 minutes per level; a daily ritual of about 30 seconds
AUDIENCE	Casual puzzle players, 25 to 45, who enjoy calm games and collecting; tarot and astrology fans the genre rarely targets
HOOK	Every level you win gives you a tarot card to keep, each with a one-line insight
BUSINESS MODEL	Free to play. Rewarded ads and small purchases for extra moves and boosters (designed, not active)
CONTENT	The Fool's Journey: 85 levels in 22 chapters on a map, 11 board shapes, 3 blockers, 5 specials and 6 combos, 3 boosters, 78 cards, a story told by Pip the dog
STATUS	Playable in Unity 6 and in the browser (itch.io): all systems in, 153 automated rule tests, every level balanced by simulation

How this document relates to the build. Everything marked **LIVE** is in the playable build. Items marked **PROPOSED** are designed and have code hooks, but are not switched on. Numbers in the balancing chapter come from the game's own rules, run by a bot, not from estimates.

PILLARS AND AUDIENCE

Four rules that every feature was checked against.

1

READABLE AT A GLANCE

Every tile differs in colour *and* shape and carries a glyph, so the board reads in sunlight and for colour-blind players.

In the game: Six silhouettes: rounded square, circle, diamond, hexagon, arch, octagon.

2

EVERY WIN GIVES YOU SOMETHING TO KEEP

The reward for a level is a card with art and a line of insight, not just stars and points.

In the game: 78-card deck, foil editions for skilful wins, a collection screen that fills visibly.

3

GENTLE, NOT PUNISHING

Mistakes cost nothing and dead ends are the game's fault, never the player's.

In the game: Free invalid swaps, automatic reshuffle, a once-per-attempt rescue, no energy system, kind texts.

4

SATISFYING FEEDBACK

Every action answers with motion, light, particles and sound, timed to feel snappy.

In the game: Tuned timings in one asset; chimes that climb a scale with each cascade.

TARGET PLAYER

Primary: casual mobile puzzle players (roughly 25 to 45) who play in short breaks, like a sense of progress and enjoy collecting. They know match-3 conventions and expect them to work.

Secondary: players drawn to tarot, astrology and "cosy" aesthetics. The theme and the daily draw give them a reason to open a puzzle game they might otherwise pass by.

WHAT THEY WANT

- A game they can put down at any moment without losing anything.
- Visible progress that isn't just a level number.
- A calm mood: no timers, no shouting, no punishment.
- Something to look forward to tomorrow.

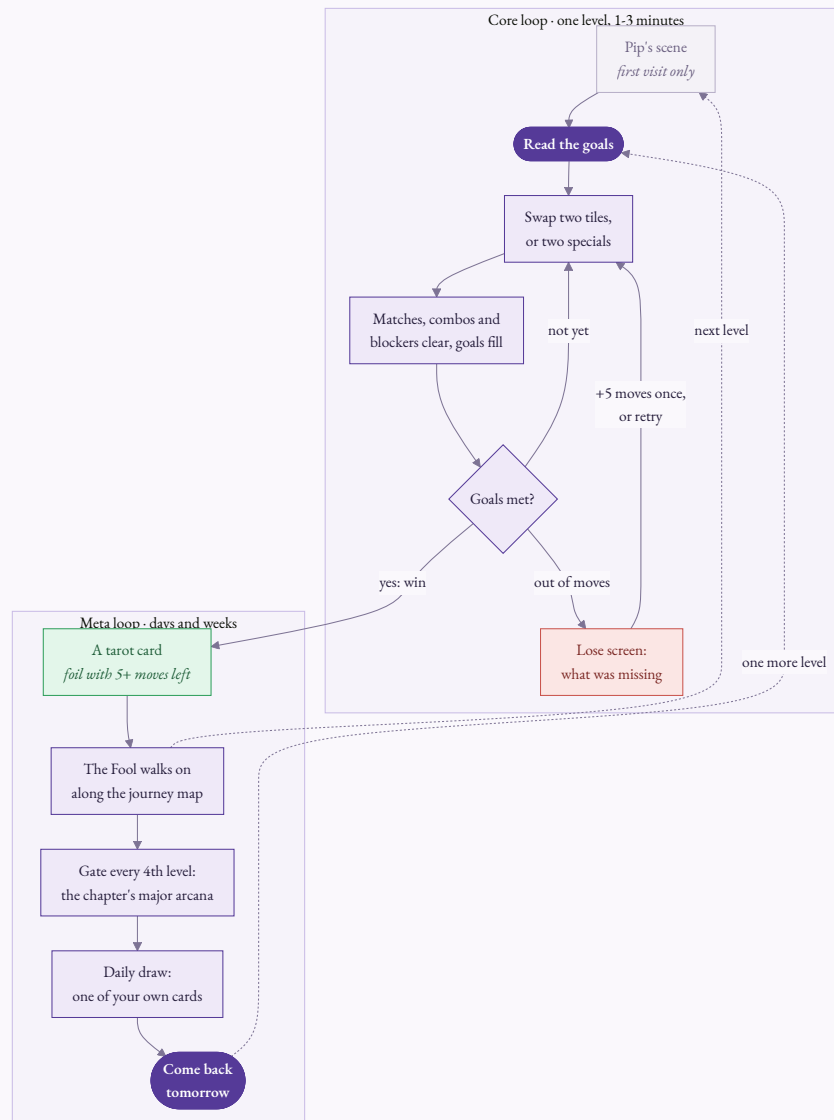
POSITIONING

TYPICAL MATCH-3		ARCANA MATCH
Reward for a level	Stars, coins, a map step	A tarot card with art and an insight, a step on the Fool's Journey, foil for mastery
Reason to return	Lives refill, events, streaks	One daily draw from your own deck, with no streak to lose
Tone	Loud and bright	Night-sky palette, glass-bell sounds, reflective texts
Stuck boards	Often costs a life or a booster	Always reshuffled for free
Readability	Often colour only	Colour, shape and glyph on every tile
Story	A decorating meta, light lore	The 22 major arcana as chapters, narrated by the Fool's dog; blockers that match each card

The design deliberately keeps genre conventions (a level map, swipe to swap, lines, specials and combos, blockers, move limits) so the game is instantly familiar, and puts its originality into the reward, the theme and the tone.

CORE AND META LOOPS

The core loop is the moment-to-moment puzzle; the meta loop is the reason to play one more level and to come back tomorrow.



CORE LOOP

- **Read** the goal pills (for example *30 Wands + 17 Cups*) and the move counter.
- **Swap** two neighbours by swipe or tap-tap. Only swaps that make a match are accepted.
- **Resolve**: matches clear, goals count up live, tiles fall and cascade, specials form and chain.
- **Decide** again, with boosters as optional tools. A level lasts 18 to 24 moves.

META LOOP

- Each win **unlocks a card**; winning with 5+ moves left makes it **foil**.
- The **journey map** moves on: the Fool walks to the next level, and each chapter's gate awards its major arcana.
- The **collection** fills visibly: 22 majors and four suits of 14.
- At 3 cards the **daily draw** opens: one card a day from your own deck.
- The draw brings players back; Pip's next scene and the next gate give them a reason to play on.

Session shape. Open the app → daily draw (30 s) → map → one to three levels (2 to 8 min) → close. Nothing decays while the player is away, so a missed day costs nothing.

THE FOOL'S JOURNEY

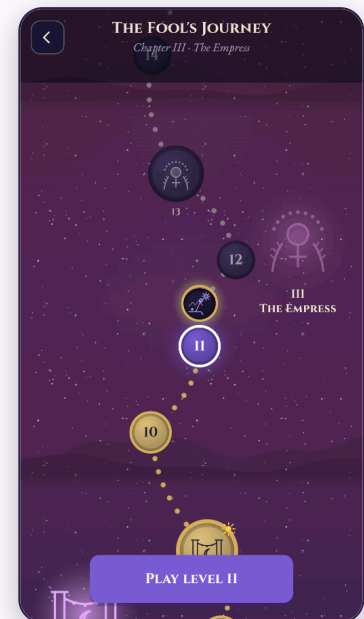
The levels are the tarot's own story: the Fool walks through the 22 major arcana, one chapter each.

STRUCTURE

PART	LEVELS	WHAT HAPPENS
Prologue	1	The Fool sets out. Win to earn The Fool .
Chapters I to XXI	2 to 85	Four levels each: three suit levels, then a gate that awards that chapter's major arcana, in order.
Beyond	86 on	The road goes on: endless suit levels for players who finish.

- **Suit levels** cycle Wands, Cups, Swords and Pentacles across the three slots, and give a random card of that suit.
- **Gates** are the difficulty spikes: a second goal (a suit, or every blocker on the board) on a special layout.
- The next chapter opens with a **breather**, and Pip tells the new chapter's scene.
- Neighbouring levels never ask for the same suit (a unit test checks the whole journey).

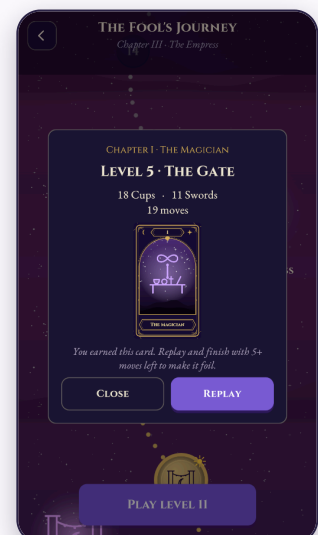
Design fix, found in my own spreadsheet. In v1, majors came every 4th level while suits rotated every level, so every Pentacles level was a major level and Pentacles cards only arrived late. Moving majors to chapter gates, with three suit slots per chapter, gives every suit its own card levels: 15 or 16 suit levels per suit for 14 cards.



The journey map: chapter regions, the Fool's marker, gold nodes for won levels

THE MAP

- A scrolling path from the prologue at the bottom to The World at the top. Each chapter is a region tinted with its card's sky colour and marked by the card's emblem, which lights up once earned.
- Level medallions show **done** (gold, with a star if foil), **current** (glowing) and **locked**; gates carry the major's emblem.
- After a win, the Fool **walks** along the path to the next level while the map follows him.
- Tapping a reached level opens its goals and the card it gave; finished levels can be **replayed for foil**, and a level always shows the same card ([LevelRewards](#) remembers it).



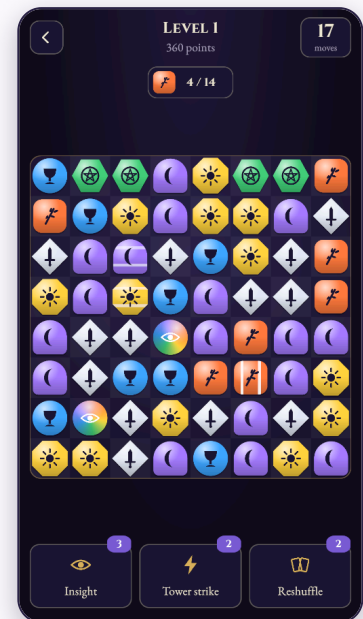
Level info: chapter, goals, the card earned, replay

THE BOARD

Genre-standard rules, with every edge case resolved in the player's favour.

TILE	SHAPE	ROLE
	Wands	Orange rounded square
	Cups	Blue circle
	Swords	Silver diamond
	Pentacles	Green hexagon
	Moon	Violet arch
	Sun	Gold octagon

Four suits carry the theme and the goals. Moon and Sun never appear in goals: they exist so that only about a third of the board is ever the target suit, which makes goals take real effort.



Level 1: goal pill, move counter, 8 x 8 board, booster bar

RULES

RULE	VALUE	WHY
Grid	8 x 8 for levels 1-4, then one of 11 shapes (chapter 8)	Genre standard to learn on; shapes add variety once the rules are known.
Starting board	No matches, no 2 x 2 squares, at least one valid move	The first move is always the player's choice, never a free cascade.
Input	Swipe toward a neighbour, or tap two neighbours	Swipe is fast; tap-tap is precise and more accessible.
Invalid swap	Tiles slide over and back with a head-shake	Costs no move: a mis-swipe should never be punished.
No valid moves	Automatic gather-and-deal reshuffle	A dead board is the game's fault, so the game fixes it.
Scoring	tiles cleared x 10 x combo	Combo rises by 1 with each cascade, so chains pay more.
Goal counting	Every cleared tile of a goal suit counts, including cascades and specials	Rewards reading the board over grinding single matches.
Refill odds	Goal suits are 1.4x more likely (chapter 10)	Keeps large late-game goals reachable.
Gravity	Tiles fall straight down; around holes and fixed blockers they slide in diagonally	Shaped boards always refill; no cell is ever stranded.

SPECIAL TILES

Harder shapes make stronger tiles, and every special can set off the others.

SHAPE	MADE BY	SPECIAL	EFFECT
 Line of 5+		Arcana tile <i>spinning rainbow with an eye</i>	Swap with any tile: clears every tile of that type, scored x2. Swap two Arcana: clears the board. Hit by another effect: clears the most common type.
 L or T shape (5+)		Star <i>four-point star of light</i>	Clears its whole row and column.
 Line of 4		Row / column clearer <i>stripes</i>	A horizontal 4 makes a column clearer, a vertical 4 a row clearer: the beam crosses the line you made, reaching fresh tiles.
 2 x 2 square		Wheel <i>a slowly turning ring of beads</i>	Clears the 3 x 3 block around it.

MAKING SPECIALS FEEL FAIR

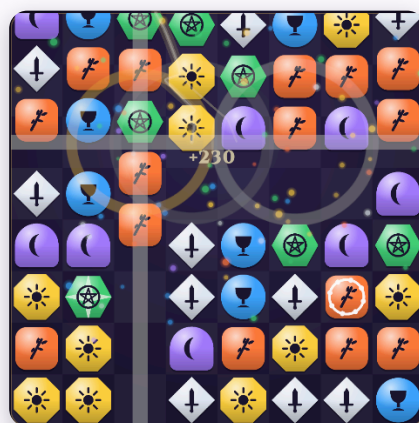
- **Priority:** when shapes overlap, the rarer special wins: Arcana > Star > line clearer > Wheel. A harder shape is never “downgraded”.
- **Aim:** a special made by the player's swap appears on the swapped cell, so it can be placed on purpose. Cascade-made specials appear in the middle of the shape (the corner of an L).
- **Chains:** effects travel through other specials. A Star crossing a Wheel fires it, which can hit an Arcana tile, and so on. Each special fires once per chain, so chains always end.
- **Readable:** each special has a distinct overlay, motion and sound, so the player learns them by sight and ear, without a tutorial screen.
- **Combos:** swapping two specials into each other combines them (chapter 7).

Playtest change. The prototype only rewarded straight lines of 4 and 5, so specials were rare and every player met the same two. Squares and L/T shapes are common on a match-3 board, so adding the Wheel and the Star gave players more ways to aim for a special and more variety in what the board does.

The orientation rule for line clearers is deliberate: the beam crosses the line the player just made, so it reaches new tiles instead of a row that is already emptying.



Specials waiting on the board: two Stars (four-point light) and a Wheel (bead ring, right)



A Star fires: row and column beams, rings, sparks and a +230 floater



An Arcana tile fires: violet lightning to every tile of one type

SPECIAL COMBOS

Swap two special tiles into each other, whatever their colours, and they combine into something bigger.

SWAP	COMBO	EFFECT
Line + line	Cross	The row and the column through the swap
Line + Wheel, or Star + line	Big cross	Three rows and three columns
Wheel + Wheel	Big wheel	The 5 x 5 block around the swap
Star + Wheel	Star wheel	The big cross and the 5 x 5 block together
Star + Star	Starburst	Row, column and both diagonals
Arcana + any special	Arcana infusion	Every tile of that special's colour becomes that special, then they all fire (line clearers alternate direction)
Arcana + Arcana	Clear the board	As before: every tile

WHY COMBOS

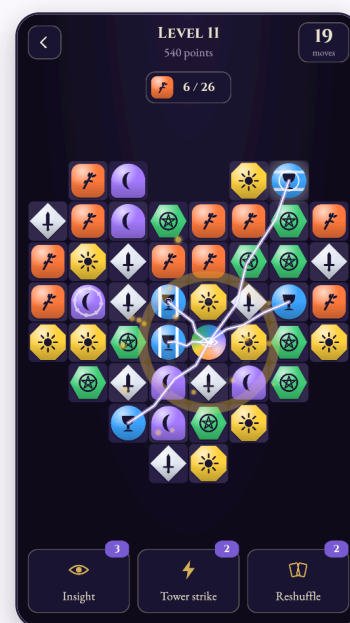
- **Genre expectation.** Players of Royal Match or Candy Crush try swapping two specials; rejecting that swap would feel broken.
- **A second layer of planning.** Making one special is a local decision; parking two next to each other is a plan across several moves, which rewards skilled players without punishing casual ones.
- **Big moments.** Each combo has its own light show (gold flash, beams including diagonals, lightning for infusions) and a rising chord, so the payoff matches the effort.

RULES

- A special + special swap is always valid, even if it makes no match: it costs a move and fires at once.
- Combos score at x2, chain through any other specials they reach, and damage blockers.
- 11 unit tests cover every pairing, the infusion counts, and that the board is full and stable afterwards.



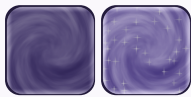
Star + Star on the Heart board: the starburst



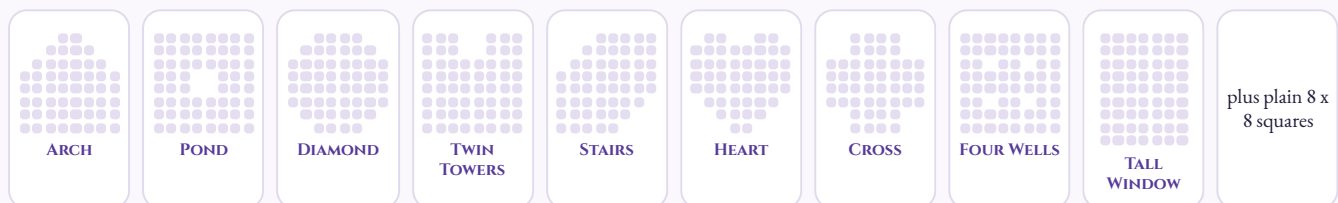
Arcana + line: an infusion, lightning to every tile of the colour

BLOCKERS AND BOARD SHAPES

From level 5 the board changes shape, and from chapter II every gate adds a blocker that fits its card.

	BLOCKER	RULE	WHAT IT TEACHES
	Veil (1 or 2 layers)	Covers a cell. Clearing the tile underneath lifts one layer. Tiles pass through it.	Aiming matches at specific cells
	Shackle	The tile can't be swapped and doesn't fall, but it can still match; matching it breaks the chain.	Working around locked tiles
	Stone Seal	Fills a cell; nothing falls through. Breaks when a neighbour clears or an effect reaches it.	Opening up the board; specials matter more

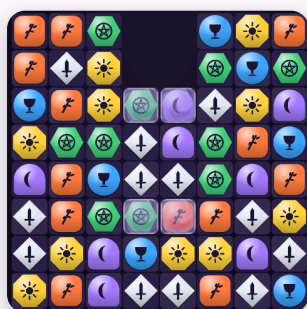
BOARD SHAPES



- An 11-entry rotation from level 5. Eleven, not twelve, so the cycle drifts against the 4-level chapters and every shape lands on a gate at some point.
- Goals scale with the open cells; shapes with holes in the middle (Pond, Four Wells) break cascades, so they take a smaller goal and fewer blockers.
- Gravity slides tiles diagonally around holes and fixed blockers, and placement rules (no fixed blocker touching another or a hole) mean every cell always refills. A test deals and plays every journey level to prove it.

GATES, THEMED TO THEIR CARD

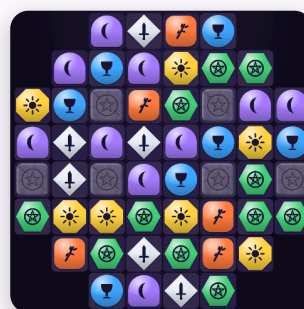
	CARD	BLOCKER	WHY
II	The High Priestess	Veils	Her curtain spills onto the road
V	The Hierophant	Shackles	Old rules bind
VII	The Chariot	Seals	Stone slabs across the road
IX	The Hermit	Veils	Mist off the peaks
X	Wheel of Fortune	Shackles	Chained to the wheel
XI	Justice	Seals	Old verdicts
XII	The Hanged Man	Shackles	Tied up and waiting
XIII	Death	Seals	Gravestones
XIV	Temperance	Thick veils	Water poured slowly



Gate II: veils



Gate V: shackles



Gate VII: Stone Seals



The Heart

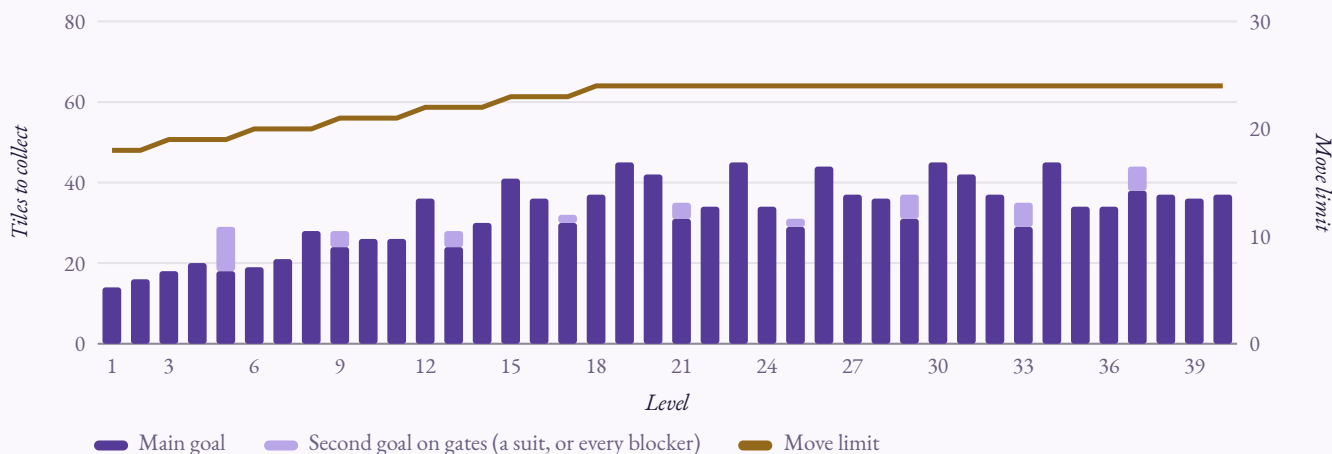
LEVELS AND DIFFICULTY

85 levels generated from a few rules, so the whole journey exists without hand-placing every tile.

```
goal = min(12 + 2n, 45) x board size
      of the level's suit
gate + a second suit min(8 + n, 30),
      or every blocker (chapter II on;
      suit goal x 0.85)
moves = 18 + min(floor(n / 3), 6)
board = square to level 4, then the
       11-shape rotation
```

- Goals grow by 2 tiles a level and moves by 1 every 3 levels, so pressure rises smoothly; caps stop it running away.
- **Board size** scales the goal: a 52-cell Arch asks for about 80% of a square's goal.
- **Gates** are the spikes; the next chapter opens with a breather.
- Numbers are the **defaults**; every level can be replaced by a hand-made one ([LevelCatalog](#)), which is the next step for level design.

DIFFICULTY CURVE, LEVELS 1 TO 40



THE FIRST CHAPTERS

LV	ROLE	BOARD	GOALS	MOVES	CARD
1	Prologue	Square	14 Wands	18	The Fool
2	Suit	Square	16 Cups	18	Random Cups
3	Suit	Square	18 Swords	19	Random Swords
4	Suit	Square	20 Pentacles	19	Random Pentacles
5	Gate	Arch	18 Cups + 11 Swords	19	The Magician
6	Suit	Pond	19 Wands	20	Random Wands
7	Suit	Diamond	21 Cups	20	Random Cups
8	Suit	Square	28 Swords	20	Random Swords
9	Gate	Twin Towers	24 Wands + 4 Veils	21	The High Priestess

BALANCING WITH A SIMULATOR

A bot plays the real game rules, every level, many times; tuning decisions rest on data as well as feel.

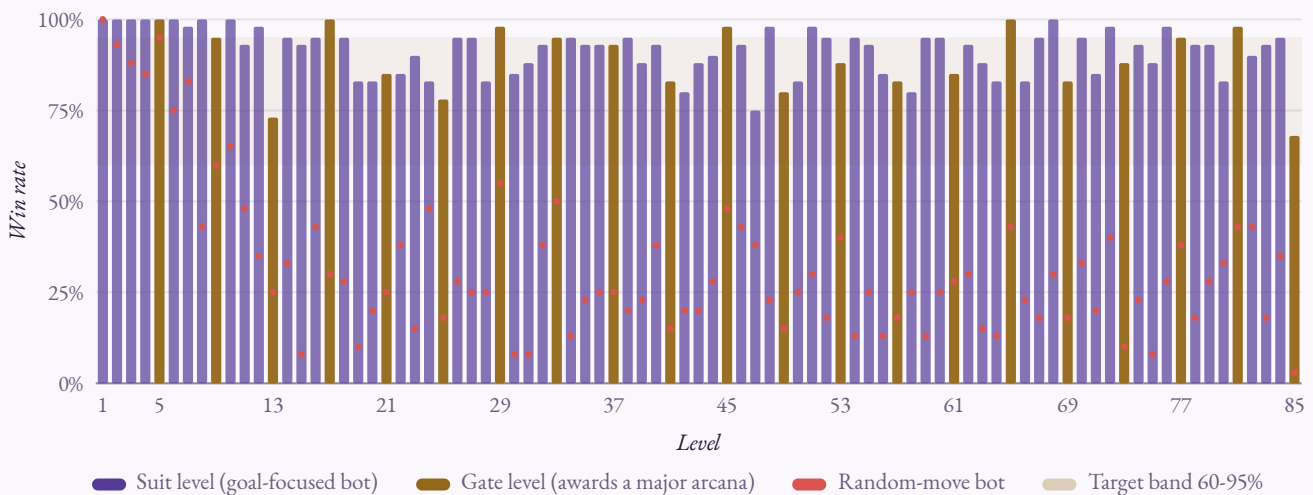
The method. `LevelSimulator` runs the shipped rules (the same resolver, cascades, specials, combos and blockers) with a *goal-focused* bot, which picks the move that clears the most goal tiles and blockers, standing in for a skilled player, and a *random* bot as a floor. It also runs outside Unity as a console app for speed.

Decision 1: goal-tile odds. Late levels stalled with every tile equally likely. A sweep of spawn weights (below) chose **1.4x** for goal suits, lifting level 18 from 33% to 85% wins while keeping foil clearly harder.

Decision 2: shapes and gates. The first run of the journey showed three walls: shapes with middle holes (43 to 65%), thick veils on small boards (35%) and shackles on Four Wells (40 to 45%). Fixes, each re-simulated: an 11-shape rotation, smaller goals on holey shapes, capped blocker counts, and 15% less suit goal on blocker gates.

Result, 40 games per level. Suit levels 75% to 100% (average 92%); gates 68% to 100% (average 89%); the random bot wins only 25% of levels after 40, so thinking matters.

EVERY LEVEL OF THE JOURNEY



THE BOOST SWEEP THAT CHOSE 1.4X



Sweep run on the original curve (before the journey); the journey keeps the 1.4x weight. Data: `Portfolio/data/journey.csv` and `boost_sweep.csv`.

BOOSTERS, WINNING AND LOSING

Boosters are tools, not a toll: none of them costs a move, and the dangerous one has a safety catch.

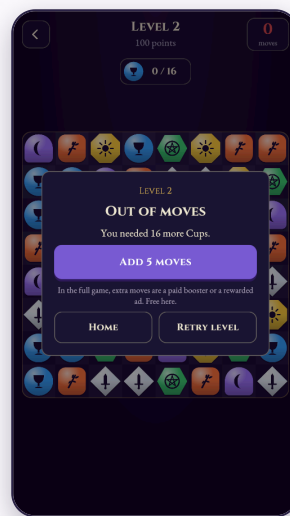
BOOSTER	START	EFFECT	DESIGN ROLE
Insight	3	Board dims, an eye opens, two orbs fly to a valid move, which pulses	Removes frustration when stuck and quietly teaches patterns.
Tower Strike	2	Armed first (gold frame + prompt); tap a tile and lightning clears its 3 x 3, firing specials	Finish a goal or break a stubborn corner. Arming prevents a wasted stray tap.
Reshuffle	2	Tiles spin to the centre and are dealt out again	A fresh board when the layout looks hopeless.



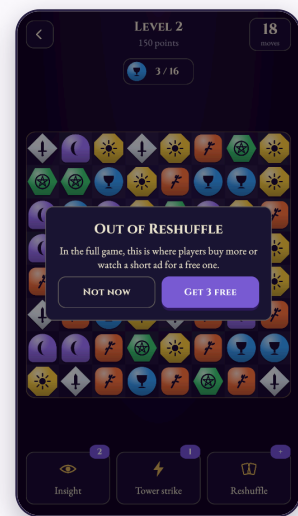
Insight



Tower Strike armed



Lose: what was missing



Refill: the store hook

WIN, LOSE AND THE RESCUE

- **Win is checked before lose**, so completing the goals on the last move is a win.
- Winning with **5 or more moves left** earns the foil card: optional mastery on top of the goal.
- Progress only moves forward: replaying an old level never lowers it.
- The lose screen says exactly what was missing (*You needed 3 more Cups*).
- **Add 5 moves** is offered once per attempt, then Retry or Home.
- An empty booster shows +; tapping it opens the refill screen (+3, free in this build).

THE COLLECTION META

The reward for a level is a card you keep. The deck is the player's record of their journey.



THE DECK

All 78 tarot cards: 22 major arcana and 56 minor (Ace to Ten, Page, Knight, Queen and King in four suits). Every card has original art generated from code (new emblems for all majors and court cards, an arched night-sky window tinted per card) and a one-line insight. The middle card is a foil edition.

IX · THE HERMIT

Some time alone will help you think clearly.

XVI · THE TOWER

A sudden shake-up can clear the way for something truer.

XIX · THE SUN

Warmth and small joys are on your side today.

UNLOCK RULES

LEVEL	CARD POOL
Prologue (1)	The Fool, the start of the tarot journey
Gates	That chapter's major arcana, in order: The Magician at 5, The World at 85
Suit levels	A random card of the level's suit you don't own
Pool empty	Falls back to any missing card

The 85-level journey completes the deck with room to spare, with no duplicates (a test plays it all). Each level remembers its card, so a replay can upgrade that card to foil but never deals a new one.

Fixed: found in the card catalogue spreadsheet. In v1, majors every 4th level lined up with the 4-suit rotation, so every Pentacles level gave a major. Majors now sit on chapter gates, and every suit gets its own card levels.

Playtest change. The prototype dealt cards in a fixed order, so every deck looked the same and the next reward was predictable. Random draws within each pool keep the structure (majors as milestones, suits matching the level) while making each unlock a small surprise and each player's collection their own.

Foil is earned by winning with 5+ moves left: an animated rainbow frame and a sweeping shine. A card never loses its foil, so skilled replays add value without undoing progress.

DAILY DRAW

Unlocks at 3 cards. Once per calendar day the player taps a face-down card and it turns over to show a card from **their own** collection, with its insight.

- Drawing from owned cards makes the collection matter: a bigger deck means a more varied draw.
- One draw a day and **no streak to lose**: a reason to return that never punishes a missed day.
- The draw sits one tap from Play, so the ritual leads naturally into a level.



STORY: PIP, THE FOOL'S DOG

The little white dog from the Fool card tells the journey: loyal, excitable, a bit cheeky, and the only one who notices the cliff.

WHY A DOG

- He's already on the card: the Fool's companion, traditionally the one who warns him of the cliff. Tarot fans recognise him; everyone else just sees a friendly dog.
- His name, **Pip**, is also the tarot word for the suit symbols on minor cards.
- A narrator who isn't the hero can be funny about him, which keeps the tone light around serious cards like Death and the Devil.



Five moods, drawn from code, set per line of the script.



Pip before chapter XV, over a dimmed board

WHEN HE SPEAKS

SCENE	WHEN	PURPOSE
Prologue	Before level 1	Hook, character, the first rule (swap to match three)
Chapter opening (21)	First level of each chapter	Meet the major arcana: a place, a character, a joke
Gate (21)	Before each gate	Lore that introduces the gate's blocker in the card's own terms
Tips (4)	Levels 2, 3, 4, 7	Foil, specials, boosters, combos: taught in character, just in time
Finale	After The World	The journey loops: same cliff, different Fool

SAMPLE LINES

(happy) Oh! Hello. I'm Pip. That's my human up ahead: the Fool. Walking toward a cliff, eyes on the sky.

(worried) Chains! Some of the tiles are locked in old chains. "Tradition," he says.

(sly) Here's the Devil's secret: his chains only hold what stands still. So we move. Match them.

(wow) THE TOWER IS ON FIRE. Lightning, falling stones, a crown flying off, everything at once!

WRITING AND TOOLS

- The whole story is one plain text file (`Data/Story.txt`) a writer edits without code: `[key]` starts a scene, `(mood)` sets Pip's face.
- Each scene plays once, never on replays; Skip is always there, and the board stays locked while he talks.
- Tests check every scene the game asks for exists and every line fits the bubble.
- Mechanics are introduced through the story: the High Priestess's curtain becomes the first veil, the Hierophant's old rules the first chains.

ECONOMY AND MONETISATION

Designed as optional time-savers on top of a game that is completely finishable for free. **PROPOSED**

RESOURCES

RESOURCE	SOURCE (FREE)	SINK	STATUS
Moves	Level's move limit (18 to 24)	One per accepted swap	LIVE
+5 moves	Once per attempt on the lose screen	Continues the level	LIVE, FREE
Insight / Tower Strike / Reshuffle	3 / 2 / 2 at start; +3 per refill	One per use; never costs a move	LIVE, FREE
Cards	One per level won	None: cards are never spent	LIVE
Foil	Win with 5+ moves left	None: permanent	LIVE

MONETISATION HOOKS

HOOK	MOMENT	REWARDED AD	PURCHASE (PROPOSED PRICE)
Extra moves	Lose screen, once per attempt	Watch for +5 moves	+5 moves, US\$0.99
Booster refill	Tapping an empty booster	Watch for +1	Bundle of 3, US\$1.99; mixed pack of 9, US\$4.99
Card sleeves (cosmetic)	Collection screen	No	Alternative card backs, US\$2.99
Remove ads	Settings	n/a	One-time US\$3.99

ETHICAL GUARDRAILS

- No energy or lives system: the player can always play the next level.
- No card can be bought. Every card is earned by play; the collection stays honest.
- No forced interstitials mid-level; ads are always opt-in and rewarded.
- One rescue per attempt, so the lose screen is not a paywall loop.

IMPLEMENTATION

Every purchase and ad goes through `IStoreService` and `IAdService`. The build ships a placeholder that grants everything for free, so the whole flow (lose → offer → success → +5 moves) is already testable. Swapping in a real store is one class, with no gameplay changes.

Prices are placeholders to validate in a soft launch, not tested numbers.

UX, SCREENS AND ACCESSIBILITY

Three screens and a handful of panels: the player is never more than two taps from playing.



SCREEN MAP

SCREEN / PANEL	PURPOSE	KEY ACTIONS
Home	Title, card fan, progress	Journey (level n) · Collection (x of 78) · Daily draw · Sound · Reset
Journey map	Where you are in the story	Scroll the path · tap the current level to play · tap an old one for its info
Level info	Goals and reward	Chapter and role · goals · the card earned (foil star) · Play or Replay
Level	The puzzle	HUD: back to the map, level and score, moves; goal pills; board; booster bar
Pip	Story and tips	Tap to finish a line or go on · Skip; plays once per scene
Win panel	Celebrate and reward	Card flips in, insight, foil note · Continue (the Fool walks on) · Map
Lose panel	Explain and rescue	What was missing · Add 5 moves (once) · Retry · Home
Refill panel	Store hook	Buy / watch for +3 · Close
Collection	The deck	Majors and four suits with counts; locked slots; tap for detail
Daily draw	Ritual	Locked (N more) · Face-down card · Today's card

LAYOUT

- Portrait at a 1080 x 1920 reference; scales to any phone.
- Respects the safe area (notches, cutouts, the home bar).
- The board sizes itself to the space the HUD leaves, so it's as large as possible on every screen.
- Thumb zone: boosters at the bottom, information at the top.

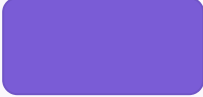
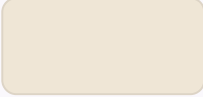
ACCESSIBILITY

- Colour, shape and glyph on every tile: three independent cues.
- Touch targets of at least 106 px at the reference size.
- Tap-tap as an alternative to swiping.
- No timers anywhere; a mute toggle that is saved.

ART DIRECTION

A tarot deck read by candlelight: deep night sky, antique gold, and jewel-bright tiles that glow against it.

PALETTE

					
Night #110d1d Background	Panel #1d1733 Cards, panels	Accent #7a5cd6 Buttons, focus	Gold #d9b35c Frames, success	Parchment #efe6d6 Text	Muted #a99fbd Secondary text

TILES: COLOUR, SILHOUETTE AND GLYPH



Wands
#ff7a3d



Cups
#3da5ff



Swords
#c9d2e3



Pentacles
#43d17a



Moon
#a57cff



Sun
#ffd23f

TYPOGRAPHY

CINZEL BOLD

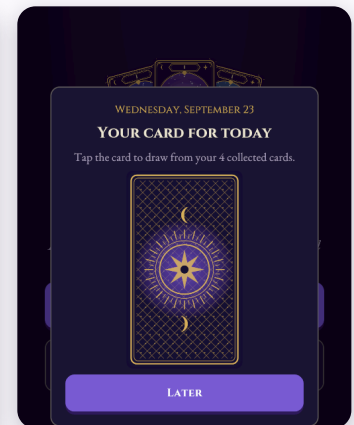
Titles, card names, buttons. Roman inscriptional capitals suit the tarot's classical imagery.

EB Garamond Italic

Body text and insights. A book face that reads well small and feels like a printed guidebook. Both are SIL Open Font License.

CARDS

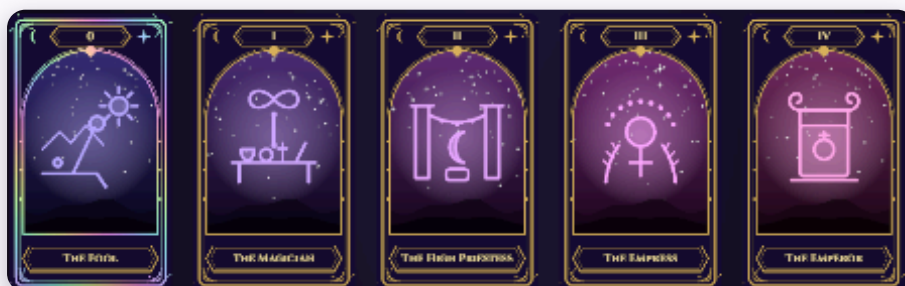
Each card is composed at runtime from shared layers (sky window tinted per card, one of four star fields, hills, halo, emblem or pips, ornate frame, cartouche and banner with live text) instead of 78 full images: about 90 MB saved, and every card stays consistent.



PRINCIPLES

- Dark theme only: tiles and effects read best against the night sky, and it's easy on the eyes at night.
- Light is the reward: every positive event adds glow, sparks or a beam.
- All art is original and generated by editor scripts (tiles, cards, blockers, the map and Pip), so it can be restyled consistently.

THE MAJOR ARCANA IN THE COLLECTION: EACH CARD'S SKY IS TINTED ALONG A COLOUR WHEEL



AUDIO

Every sound and the music are original, synthesized from code, so the whole soundscape can be re-tuned in minutes.

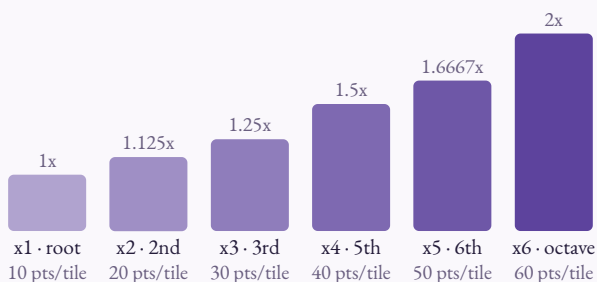
EVENT	SOUND	INTENT
Match	FM glass bell; pitch climbs a pentatonic step per cascade	Rewards chains audibly; pentatonic never clashes
Special made	Rising arpeggio	Tells the player they made something
Line / Star beam	Bright zing	Sells the sweep of light
Wheel	Deep thump (the thunder, pitched down)	A weighty local blast with a small board shake
Arcana	Electric crackle; for two, a swelling rush and boom	The biggest moment gets the biggest sound
Tower Strike	Thunder	Matches the lightning bolt
Combo	Rising chord and shimmer	The biggest planned moment
Veil / chain / seal	Cloth swish / chain clink / stone crack	Each blocker sounds like its material
Pip	A small yip on each scene	Character in one sound
Insight	Upward sparkle	Magical, helpful
Reshuffle	Card riffle	A real deck being shuffled
Card flip / foil	Swish / glitter	The reward reveal
Win / lose	Blooming chord / three soft falling notes	Disappointing, never harsh (the gentle pillar)
Invalid swap	Two soft wooden bonks	A gentle "nope", never a buzzer

MUSIC: TWO MOODS

"Night Sky" (home and map): a 32-second ambient loop in D minor with sparse bells. "The Fool's Stride" (levels): 104 BPM in D major, plucked bass, brushed drums and a whistled melody, written after playtesting called the single calm track "dry and sleepy". They crossfade over 0.9 s.

THE COMBO SCALE

Combo x1 plays the root; x2 a whole tone higher; x3 a major third; x4 a fifth, and so on up the scale. A long cascade audibly builds, which makes chains feel earned.



IMPLEMENTATION

- **SoundGenerator** writes every WAV: FM bells, filtered noise, a plucked riffle and a soft pad.
- **AudioService** pools voices, applies combo pitch, and keeps the music under the effects.
- Mix levels and pitches live in the **SoundBank** asset.
- A speaker button on Home mutes everything; the setting is saved.

GAME FEEL

Timings were found in the browser prototype and carried over exactly; all of them live in one tuning asset.

MOMENT	FEEDBACK	TIMING
Swap	Tiles glide on a cubic-bezier(.25, .8, .35, 1) curve	0.26 s move, 0.21 s beat
Invalid swap	Slide over, slide back, head-shake	0.25 s shake
Clear	Tiles grow to 135% and fade; coloured sparks; +points and Combo x n float up	0.2 s pop, 0.22 s beat
Fall and refill	New tiles drop in from above the board	0.3 s
Special created	White ring pulse where it appears	0.2 s
Line / Star clear	A band of light sweeps the row and/or column	0.45 s
Wheel	White ring, gold sparks, a small board shake	0.4 s ring, 0.25 s shake
Arcana	Violet lightning arcs to every target; they flicker, then clear together	0.38 s wind-up
Tower Strike	Board dims, jagged bolt, white flash, shake, rings, sparks	about 0.41 s to the clear
Insight	Board dims, an eye opens, two orbs fly to the hinted tiles	about 1.3 s
Reshuffle	Tiles spin into the centre, then are dealt back out one by one	0.36 s gather, 0.42 s deal
Combo	Gold flash, beams (diagonals for stars), board shake	0.5 s
Blocker hit	Veil lifts and fades, chain snaps, stone cracks into chips	0.25 to 0.35 s
Card unlock	Card turns over, then its insight fades in	flip at 0.45 s, text at 1.1 s

HUD FEEDBACK

- Goal pills bump when they progress and turn gold with a tick when met.
- Goal counters fill *as each clear animates*, not at the end of the turn, so a cascade visibly pays out.
- The move counter pulses on change and turns red at 5.
- Specials use distinct motion: the Arcana tile spins, the Wheel slowly turns, stripes shimmer.

Why a tuning asset? A designer can change any timing during Play mode and feel the difference immediately, without touching code or waiting for a compile.

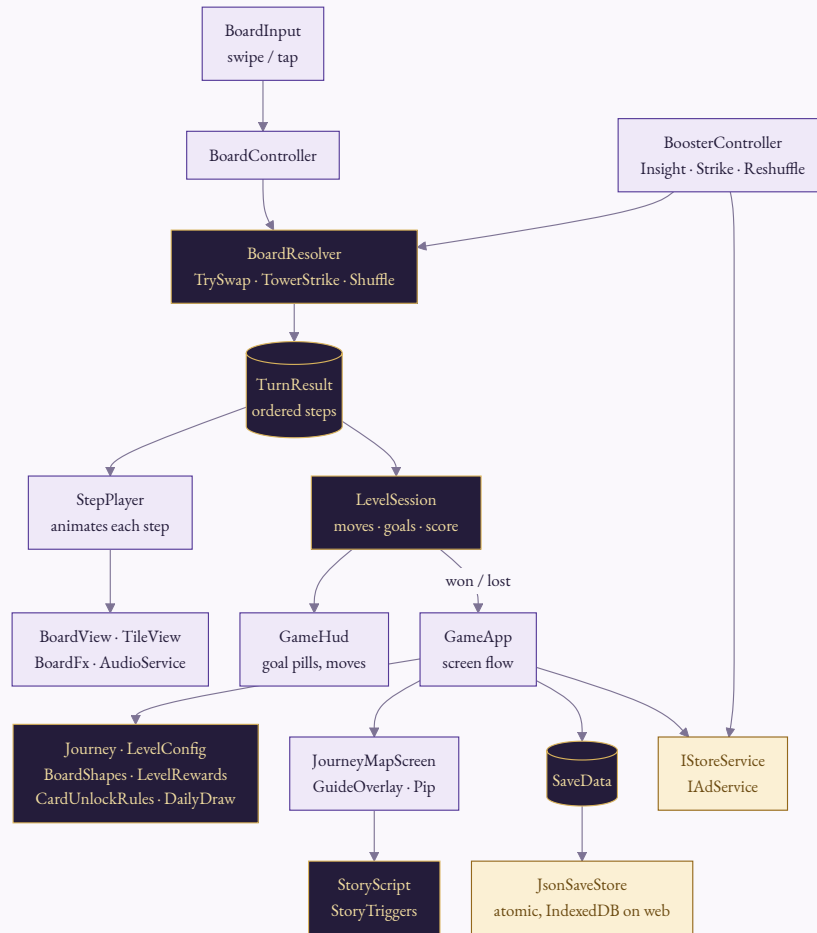


Arcana blast: lightning to every target

Tower Strike

TECHNICAL DESIGN

Rules in plain C#, animation as playback: the design stays testable and the view can never disagree with the rules.



KEY DECISIONS

- **The model never waits for animation.** A move resolves instantly into an ordered list of steps (swap, clear, special created, combo, blockers hit, fall, shuffle, blast); `StepPlayer` animates them.
- **Deterministic rules.** Randomness is injected (`IRandom`), so tests and the balance simulator are repeatable.
- **Data-driven.** Cards, tile looks, timings, sounds and Pip's story (a plain text file) are assets a designer can edit.
- **No third-party packages.** Tweening, effects and shaders are small in-house pieces.

QUALITY AND TOOLING

- **153 EditMode tests** cover matching, generation, cascades, specials, combos, blockers, shaped gravity, the whole 85-level journey (every board deals and refills), card unlocks, the story script, the daily draw and saving.
- **Reproducible project:** art, fonts, the 78-card deck, sounds and the main scene are generated by editor menu items.
- **Builds:** one-click Android APK and a mobile web build (safe area, portrait prompt, home-screen install, saves in IndexedDB) for playtesters on any phone.

PLAYTESTING AND ITERATION

Built in seven checkpointed phases; each one was played and steered before the next was built on top of it.

1 · PLAN Prototype study, architecture, design pillars	2 · BOARD Matching, cascades, swipe and tap, animation playback	3 · LEVELS Goals, moves, HUD, win and lose flow	4 · FEEL Specials, boosters, particles, beams, lightning	5 · META 78 cards, collection, daily draw, foil, saving	6 · SHIP Android and web builds, sound, tuning	7 · JOURNEY Map, combos, blockers, shapes, music, Pip
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WHAT TESTING CHANGED

OBSERVATION	CHANGE	HOW IT WAS CHECKED
Late levels could stall: not enough goal tiles appeared.	Goal suits spawn 1.4x more often, on the starting board and in refills.	Balance simulator: win rate at level 18 rose from 33% to 85%; sweep chose the weight.
Specials were rare and always the same two.	Added the Wheel (2 x 2 square) and the Star (L/T shape), with a clear priority order.	Unit tests for every shape, overlap and chain; play sessions.
Every player got the same cards in the same order.	Random draws within each pool.	Test plays the journey: complete deck, no duplicates.
Pentacles cards arrived last (spreadsheet).	Majors moved to chapter gates on a journey map.	Card catalogue and journey tests.
Shaped boards and blocker gates were walls (43 to 45%).	11-shape rotation, smaller goals on holey shapes, capped blockers.	Simulator over all 85 levels: gates now 68 to 100%.
The game felt flat, then the music "dry and sleepy".	Synthesized effects for every event; a livelier level track with a crossfade.	Listening passes; player feedback.
Testers on iPhone could not install an APK.	Mobile web build with home-screen install and saved progress.	Checked in iPhone and Android phone emulation; saves persist.

PLAYTEST PLAN FOR THE NEXT ROUND

- 5 to 8 players, mixed match-3 experience, on their own phones via the web build.
- Silent first session (no instructions): do they discover specials and boosters?
- Watch for: first stuck moment, first booster use, reaction to the first card.
- Short survey: clarity of goals, difficulty by level, favourite special, would they return for the draw?
- Log per level: result, moves left, boosters used, extra moves taken.
- Compare real win rates with the simulator's to calibrate it.

ROADMAP, KPIS AND RISKS

What would come next if this prototype went into production.

NEXT	WHAT	WHY
Analytics	Level start / win / lose, moves left, booster use, extra-moves uptake, daily-draw return	Tune the curve on real players, not only the bot.
Hand-made gates	A level editor for layouts and blocker placement; 21 authored gate levels	Gates are the story's set pieces; generated boards are a good base, not the end.
More goal types	Collect specials, drop items to the bottom, clear all veils in few moves	Variety for levels 40+.
Live events	Seasonal decks and weekly challenge levels	Content after the 85 levels and the 78 cards.
Card journal	Note how each daily card related to your day	Deepens the ritual for the secondary audience.
Haptics and localisation	Light vibration on matches, stronger on specials; card text is already in data	Feel on device; reach.

KPIS FOR A SOFT LAUNCH

METRIC	QUESTION	TARGET
D1 / D7 / D30	Does the daily draw bring people back?	40 / 15 / 6%
Levels per session	Is one more level tempting?	3+
Level fail rate	Is any level a wall?	< 50% at any level
Extra-moves uptake	Is the rescue valued without feeling forced?	10 to 20% of losses
Daily-draw use	Is the ritual working?	50% of D1+ players

Targets are planning assumptions to validate, not measured results.

RISKS

RISK	MITIGATION
The theme alienates some players	Tarot as art and reflection, never fortune-telling; kind, general insights.
Late levels feel the same	Shapes and blockers already rotate; hand-made gates and new goals (above).
Collection ends at 78	Foil completion, card sleeves, seasonal decks as live content.
A crowded genre	Differentiate on reward, tone and ritual rather than on rules.

Credits. Design, code and art direction: Umut Eren Demirci. Built in Unity 6 with the help of Claude (Anthropic) as a coding assistant. Fonts: Cinzel (Natanael Gama) and EB Garamond (Georg Duffner, Octavio Pardo), SIL Open Font License. All other art, sound and music are original and generated by the project's editor scripts.